

Game Design Principles

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Principles

Having a defined success criteria is important for games, Elden Ring has a final boss to defeat, Counter Strike has matches to win, and Tetris has levels to beat.¹ Fairness is also an important principle to abide by, Elden Ring and Counter Strike are both good examples of abiding by fairness in their games. Giving players a sense of accomplishment throughout the game is a good principle to follow in a game, this can be like in Call of Duty when you eliminate an enemy, or in God of War when you unlock a weapon after defeating a difficult enemy.

Summary and Pros and Cons of Principles

Defined Success - Defined success in a game includes what the player should be doing to win or beat the game. Pros include giving a player an objective to work towards, a reason to come back to the game, and it allows them to strategize with other mechanics of the game. Cons would include restricting player freedom on how they may want to play.

Fairness - Fairness in a game includes how balanced the game is between difficulty. Fairness determines how much your success in the game relies on skill, luck, or the mechanics in the game. Pros include preventing frustration and promoting replayability. Cons include making the game unrealistic and taking away from the immersion.

Give Player a Sense of Accomplishment - Giving the player a sense of accomplishment is important because it gives the player a reason to complete the objective. It can be subtle, like earning XP, acquiring currency, levelling up, or winning a match, but it provides the player with a sense of joy for playing the game, which directly contributes to their fun. Pros include giving the player a reason to finish objectives. Cons include changing the fundamentals of the game, since not every game needs to have an objective to 'win'.

Summary of Each Principle in My Game

Defined Success - Defining success in a game makes it so the player has an objective. In my game, I plan to have a boss you have to defeat at the end of the level, and it's the player's job to use their items and mechanics in the game to do so. The whole game is built around this defined version of success, levelling up your character, acquiring materials, and levelling up. Having the game set up this way allows the player to use the mechanics strategically to attempt to reach the defined objective.

Fairness - Fairness in any game is important, especially for competitive multiplayer or difficult games. Fairness is a huge component towards replayability. It also contributes to the competitiveness of the game, because it would be based more on skill. An unfair difficult game would not be a game players would want to come back to, it's critical that difficult games seem fair. I plan to have a moderately difficult boss in my game, so it'll also be important to consider the factors to make the game fair, such as reaction time to dodge hits or the time in between attacks.

Give Player a Sense of Accomplishment - In my game, I plan to implement an XP system for defeating enemies and finding treasure to contribute to that principle, and with that XP, you can level up. You can also obtain special items and weapons from beating difficult enemies and bosses, which act as a reward for the player.

Sources

¹<https://www.thedesigngym.com/seven-principles-of-game-design-and-five-innovation-games-th-at-work/>

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